

FREEDOMS IN decline

JOSEON KOREA

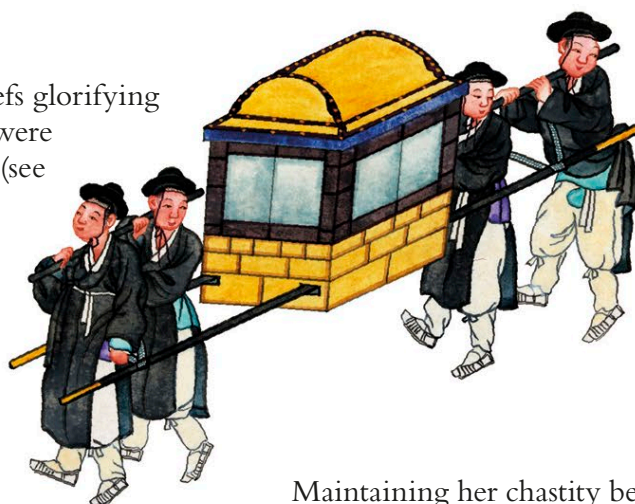
When Neo-Confucian beliefs glorifying men and the first-born son were adopted in Korea and Japan (see pp. 124–125) it led to the widespread oppression of women. The Joseon Dynasty (1392–1910) was Korea's longest-ruling Confucian dynasty, and the era when Neo-Confucianism was established as state and social ideology. Yet, despite increasing patriarchy, the dynasty was also a period of cultural development that produced female intellectuals, poets, and heroes.

Korean women had enjoyed considerably more liberty and influence during the preceding Goryeo Dynasty. The advent of the Joseon Dynasty and the ideological and legal changes it brought greatly affected women's lives. When a woman married, she no longer remained at her natal home as women had

done previously, but went to live with her husband's family, who received a dowry. This meant that having girls was expensive—for this reason, a daughter was called a *todungnyo*, or robber woman. To save a woman's share of inheritance from being given over to in-laws, it was reduced or removed entirely and male family members came to inherit most of a family's wealth.

◀ Palace women in power

This silk painting from the Joseon period depicts the court women or *gungnyeo*. They were royal slaves and, if favored by the king, could achieve rank and even wield some political power.



◀ Palanquin to patriarchy

Due to Confucian ideas about modesty, women travelled by palanquin and wore headdresses when they left their homes to hide their faces from passersby.

Maintaining her chastity became a woman's greatest responsibility to the extent that women were customarily given a *p'aedo* or suicide knife, and expected to use it if their family's honor became compromised. Royal and noblewomen were not exempt from these strictures. When the 15th-century Joseon king Seongjong discovered his cousin, the widowed princess Yi Guji, had been cohabiting with a slave after her husband's death, she was ordered to kill herself.

Almost nameless

Later in the 15th century, the Joseon king Yeonsangun took thousands of women from the provinces to serve as palace entertainers, called *gisaeng*. Although they were technically slaves, and provided sexual services, the *gisaeng* had more freedom than most women. They had no family constraints, could converse with men, and were schooled in literature, the arts, and polite conversation, as well as medicine and acupuncture. Most of the real names of *gisaeng* have been forgotten and indeed, by the end of the Joseon period, women in general were almost nameless. They were invariably referred to by their husband's or children's names, as "such-and-such's wife" or "such-and-such's mother."

